NO. 160 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 12 NOVEMBER 2026



TWO THOUSAND SOLDIERS IN HAITI; TWO HUNDRED OF THEM UNDER A MANDATE (P3)

THE WORLD

Bukele says his forces destroyed a gang headquarters outside Port-au-Prince, with no agreement published

TECHNOLOGY

Anthropic registers the largest share offering ever attempted, and its own chip suppliers are buying in

THE MACRO DESK

American inflation ran hot on Tuesday, and the Federal Reserve is now priced for a December rise

Source: Patrice Noel/Reuters, via Al Jazeera. Salvadoran Army armoured vehicles operating in Haiti, November 2026.

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THE SPINE: THE VENDORS ARE THE BUYERS. Anthropic's suppliers are funding the offering that will pay them (p7); the datacentres have bid a desktop memory kit above the price of a graphics card (p8); Singapore turns out to be where the chips are invoiced rather than installed (p5); and equities rose on Wednesday because the building looks self-financing, on the day the real cost of money reached 2.78 per cent (p14).

FROM THE DESK

"There is nothing so disturbing to one's well-being and judgment as to see a friend get rich."

Charles P. Kindleberger, *Manias, Panics, and Crashes* (1978). The wording varies between editions and this desk could not fix it to a page.[1]

For p7, where the people selling the shovels have bought the mine, and p10, where a third of a record sale was one living maker.

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.98%	▲ 10bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.78%	▲ 12bp
Breakeven[2]	2.20%	▼ 2bp
VWRA[3]	$189.62	▲ 1.46%
Gold[3]	$3,991.10	▼ 0.97%
Bitcoin[3]	$74,646	▲ 1.26%
Brent[3]	$92.53	▲ 1.14%
USD/JPY[3]	159.87	▲ 0.74%
Straits Times[3]	5,289.66	▲ 0.59%

There is no 11 November Treasury yield — the American bond market shut for Veterans Day, so the yields are Tuesday's (p14). Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · THURSDAY

No. 74, 15 August 2026, is the issue in which a reader killed a desk. Property had been the book's most-skipped page, and he said so; it was retired that day and The Atelier took its slot.

Today that desk is on a Japanese pottery (p6) that has cut its grooves by hand since 1925 and sells the result for about four Singapore dollars.

The lesson has held: of the three desks retired by reader instruction, none has been quietly reinstated, and the two replacements have run every edition since.

SOURCES 1 Widely attributed to Charles P. Kindleberger's *Manias, Panics, and Crashes: A History of Financial Crises*, first published 1978. **This desk checked and could not establish a page reference, and the wording differs between editions ("nothing so" and "nothing as"); it is printed as an attributed saying rather than a verified quotation.** 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and real yield curve files, **read at source**; the breakeven is the Federal Reserve Bank of St Louis' published ten-year series. **Every yield here is the close of Tuesday 10 November: the bond market did not open on Wednesday** (p14). 3 Levels at the close of Wednesday 11 November, each read at its own quote page and set out with its sourcing on p14; **currencies and bitcoin have no close and are snapshots taken near 21:10 GMT.**

THE WORLD · EL SALVADOR IN HAITI

Bukele says his forces destroyed 400 Mawozo's headquarters outside Port-au-Prince

About 2,000 Salvadoran soldiers are now in Haiti. Roughly 200 of them answer to the United Nations-authorised force; the agreement covering the rest has never been published.

President Nayib Bukele of El Salvador posted video on Tuesday 10 November showing helicopters over Croix-des-Bouquets, outside Port-au-Prince, and said Salvadoran forces had destroyed the house and the headquarters of the gang leader Wilson Joseph. Two of the four aircraft carried Salvadoran flags. The operation itself, the Haitian Times and France 24 both report, took place on Sunday 8 November.[1]

What makes this more than another raid is who is flying the helicopters. Most of the Salvadoran soldiers now in the country are not part of it. They are there under a bilateral arrangement between two governments, and neither will publish it — so there is no public text saying when they may shoot, or to whom a Haitian takes a complaint.[2]

The numbers set the problem out plainly. The other eighteen hundred answer to San Salvador alone.[2]

Bukele is paying for it himself — he puts El Salvador's share at **90 per cent** of the cost — and he has been explicit about what it is not. "This is not an operation against the Haitian people, nor an invasion of the country of Haiti," he said on 29 October. "We do not come to Haiti to make money, because nobody is paying us for this."[3]

Four Salvadoran aviation technicians disappeared in an ambush on 18 October and have not been accounted for since. Haiti's first elections in over a decade are scheduled for July and October 2027.[1]

Eighteen hundred soldiers, and no published document saying when they may shoot.

PORT-AU-PRINCE — HAITIAN TIMES

The diaspora paper carries a mood the human-rights statements do not. **Mathias Pierre**, a former elections official, asks: "Who really wants to end the dominance of armed gangs in Haiti, and who would benefit from its continuation?" **Winchel Walabre** is blunter — "Hey Amnesty, where were you when gangs were killing, burning homes, raping and kidnapping Haitians?"[4]

WASHINGTON — RESPONSIBLE STATECRAFT

The Quincy Institute's **Joseph Bouchard** reads Haiti as a battlefield with too many armies: the authorised force, Bukele's, and **Erik Prince**'s drone contractors. He notes a government accountability review finding **73 per cent** of traced firearms across twenty-five Caribbean countries came from the United States — the guns run one way, the interventions the other.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS SAY BUKELE IS DOING IN HAITI

The Salvadoran read is that Haiti is a stage. **Luis Enrique Amaya**, a security consultant, says Bukele "has to build this narrative of success". **Tiziano Breda** of ACLED expects a show of force and a withdrawal, not a campaign. El Salvador votes in February.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TWENTY DEAD AT CROIX-DES-BOUQUETS

The casualty figure everyone is printing rests on one newspaper's anonymous sources. Al Jazeera put "20 dead" in its headline; France 24 says plainly that the number comes from the Miami Herald citing unnamed people. **This desk is not printing twenty as a fact. That claim is itself unverified**, and no Salvadoran government response to it has been published.[7] **What would settle it:** a body count from Haiti's own police or the authorised force, and publication of the bilateral agreement that Amnesty International has demanded.[8]

SOURCES 1 Haitian Times and France 24, 11 November, both **read at source**, for the 8 November date, the helicopters and Fils-Aimé's praise; **X returned 402, so Bukele's post is quoted as four outlets carry it.** 2 UPI, 11 November, for Dujarric's count of ~200 under mandate against ~2,000 deployed. 3 elsalvador.com, 29 October, for the denial and the 90 per cent. 4 Haitian Times, as above. 5 Responsible Statecraft, 9 November — **labelled analysis; its figures are second-hand within it.** 6 El Nuevo Día, 11 November, carrying the Associated Press analysis. 7 Al Jazeera, 10 November; Ensegundos, Santo Domingo, 11 November. 8 Amnesty International's own statement of 9 November. **Reuters, the Associated Press and the Miami Herald all refused this desk, which is why the twenty is relayed and flagged.**

HORMUZ · THE ISLAND NOBODY CAN AGREE ON

Iran claims a strike on Oman's Didamar lighthouse; Muscat denies any damage

Fars News reported the strike on 10 November. Satellite images from that morning show no obvious damage, and a senior Omani official told The Maritime Executive the lights were never touched.

Iran's Revolutionary Guard said on Tuesday 10 November that it had destroyed "enemy navigation systems" on Didamar, an uninhabited Omani island in the Strait of Hormuz, because they were helping ships make unauthorised transits. A senior Omani official told the trade journal The Maritime Executive that the navigational aids were not struck.[1]

A disagreement about whether an attack happened is stranger than an attack. Didamar is a rock with a lighthouse on it, built by the British in 1914, plus a radio relay, a marine radar and the control centre that talks to passing tankers on the emergency channel. One government says it blew the equipment up. The government that owns the rock says nothing of the sort occurred.[1]

The independent evidence sits in between and settles nothing. Imagery from the morning of 10 November shows no obvious damage, though a broken mast would not necessarily be visible at that resolution.[1]

Two shipping sources and a maritime security source told the same journal that the effect on commercial traffic is likely to be small. That is the practical answer. The unanswered one is why Tehran would announce an attack on the territory of the one Gulf state that has spent the whole crisis trying not to take a side.[1]

One government says it blew the lighthouse up. The country that owns it says nothing happened.

BEIJING — XINHUA

China's wire covered the Abu Dhabi talks this week and not the Gulf. **On Didamar, and on Hormuz generally, Xinhua and the Global Times both carried nothing this week** — a silence worth recording rather than filling.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY DIDAMAR MAY BE A CLAIM, NOT AN ATTACK

The case for treating Tehran's Didamar announcement as an announcement is that every independent instrument pointed at the island has failed to find the damage. What would falsify this reading: a notice to mariners from Oman's maritime authority withdrawing the light, or higher-resolution imagery of the mast.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Abu Dhabi. No final number exists as this issue goes to press. Russia's **Vladimir Medinsky**, on the European delegates in the building: "We don't really understand in what capacity they are here."[3]

Paraguay. The thread No. 157 carried on one outlet is now on the record across UPI, CNN, the Associated Press, Reuters and the Guardian. The Senate removed President Santiago Peña **44–0** on 6 November and he was detained minutes later; Vice-President **Pedro Alliana** was sworn in that evening to serve to 2028. Ueno Bank had served about **3m clients** on a solvency ratio of **5.56 per cent** against a legal floor of 12.[4]

France. A second wave on 2 November hit grocers in at least nine other European countries. **Correction to No.** 159, which reported two units: France names one, plus its parent centre.[5]

Türkiye. An overhead crane collapsed into an electric arc furnace at Habaş's Aliağa steelworks on 9 November, killing **18** and injuring at least 12. Chairman **Mehmet Rüştü Başaran** was arrested in Istanbul the next day.[6]

Indonesia. Vice-President **Gibran Rakabuming Raka** offered his resignation on 10 November over his candidacy documents; President Prabowo's office said he did not decline it.[7]

SOURCES 1 The Maritime Executive, **read at source**, for the Fars News claim, the Omani denial, the Reuters verification of smoke and thermal activity, the 10 November imagery and the shipping read. 2 Xinhua's English service, 11 November; **the absence of Gulf coverage was checked on the Xinhua and Global Times fronts and is reported as a negative finding.** 3 Euronews, 11 November. 4 UPI, 6 November, with the chronology checked against Guardian, AP and Reuters reporting. **A pension figure circulating at both US$60m and US$380m is not printed: neither was read at an original.** 5 France 24, 9 November. **Store counts vary from 700 to over 1,000; the officially-sourced figure stands.** 6 AFP, Bianet, Deutsche Welle and Anadolu, 9–10 November. **The Morning Star's six dead was an early count and is wrong.** 7 Relayed from Reuters via two digests; **Reuters refused this desk directly.**

SINGAPORE · MEGASPEED AT COLLYER QUAY

Singapore police confirm an investigation into Megaspeed, the Nvidia customer at Ocean Financial Centre

Megaspeed's assets rose from US$33m in 2023 to US$3bn in 2024. The Home Affairs Ministry says flatly that its former managing director was never under investigation here.

The Singapore Police Force told the Wall Street Journal on 30 October that Megaspeed, a company registered at Ocean Financial Centre on Collyer Quay, is under investigation for suspected breaches of Singapore law. The alleged conduit is Megaspeed's former managing director.[1]

Singapore's exposure here is mostly an accounting one, and that is the part worth understanding first. So a number that looks like a country buying an enormous quantity of chips is, in the main, a country issuing an enormous quantity of invoices.[2]

The figures are striking either way. Nvidia billed **22 per cent** of its revenue, about US$10.2bn, to Singapore in the quarter to 27 July 2025. A Malaysian sister company is reported to have bought at least **US$4.8bn** of advanced equipment between 2024 and 2026, according to import records seen by the New York Times.[1]

The state's position has been consistent and narrow. Between February 2025 and July 2026 it charged four people and four companies — for fraud against server suppliers, not for export-control breaches, which are not Singapore offences.[1]

On 31 October the Ministry of Home Affairs issued a flat denial of the central reporting: "there were no such investigations conducted in respect of Alice Huang." China's foreign ministry spokesman Guo Jiakun called the espionage claims "baseless and slanderous" on 9 November.[1]

A country that looks like it is buying the chips is, in the main, a country issuing the invoices.

THE CHATTER · HOW SINGAPORE IS TAKING THE MEGASPEED STORY

Barely. Among analysts the read is narrower still: **Ryu Young-ho** of NH Investment & Securities notes rivals may draw attention but says "replacing Nvidia's products would be tough".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE THAT MEGASPEED IS NOT A SINGAPORE STORY

Six things cut against the chip-smuggling-hub framing, and most of them come from Nvidia's own filings. No charge has been laid against Megaspeed. The US$4.8bn of hardware sits in Malaysian import records, attached to a Johor entity. And the police investigation several aggregators have dated to October 2026 was reported by CNBC in **October 2025** — a year-old inquiry re-dated by a new board inquiry in California.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A seventh breach in a fortnight, and still almost no denominators. M1 and Doctor Anywhere have still published no victim count at all. **Four disclosures, one ratio, zero absolute numbers** — and gaps of seven to eleven days between discovery and disclosure.[5]

Three driverless incidents, and a reporting regime. After a Grab vehicle came close to a schoolgirl on Punggol Field Walk on 5 November and a ComfortDelGro vehicle turned into oncoming traffic the same day, the Land Transport Authority has ordered both operators to pause specific manoeuvres — and says it will publish a **quarterly** report on autonomous deployments from December.[6]

The haze schemes stand down today. The Haze Subsidy Scheme and the clinic programme are deactivated from **12 November**. More than **1,300** clinics took part; by 31 October there had been over **100,000** subsidised visits at clinics and 60,000 at polyclinics, capped at $10.[7]

SOURCES 1 Mothership's explainer of 11 November, carrying the corporate filings via Lianhe Zaobao, and The Star's syndication of the Straits Times report of the same day, which carries the police and Home Affairs statements verbatim — both **read at source**. **A figure of S$9.6bn circulating in aggregator headlines appears in no sourced reporting and is not printed.** 2 Nvidia's disclosed billing-location figures via CNBC, October 2025. 3 HardwareZone's EDMW board, read directly on 11 November for thread counts; **note HardwareZone is itself an SPH Media title. Reddit refused this desk in every form all build, so no r/singapore sentiment appears in this issue.** 4 CNBC, October 2025; Bloomberg's 29 October interview as reported; the ministry statement of 31 October. 5 Mothership, 10 November, and AsiaOne, 11 November. **Neither company's own page could be opened; both statements are relayed.** 6 Mothership and Yahoo Singapore, 8–11 November. 7 The Ministry of Health's own release of 5 November; **visit counts are preliminary.**

THE ATELIER · THE MORTAR AND PESTLE

Motoshige hand-cuts the grooves in a ¥462 suribachi that Rikumo resells at US$43.50

America's Test Kitchen rejected every mortar under five pounds. Singapore's main kitchenware retailer stocks three, all under 14cm and all below its useful-capacity floor.

A mortar and pestle is a tool in which the working surface does everything and the bowl is only a jig to hold the food still, and this page is about telling a good surface from a bad one in a shop. Which is why polish is the enemy, and why the most reliable test is to run a fingertip round the inside: you want it to drag like a cat's tongue.[1]

That one rule explains almost every price in the category, and it explains why the cheapest serious object in it is Japanese. Its non-recommended list is a list of smooth surfaces, including a Le Creuset set.[1]

Three materials, three different jobs. **Marble** is metamorphosed limestone at Mohs 3, softer than a peppercorn, etched by acid: right for a cold basil emulsion, wrong for everything dry.[1]

Motoshige Seitōsho of Gōtsu City, Shimane, founded 1925, is the house worth naming. Yamatada's Mino-ware 170mm is ¥3,300; a magnolia pestle ¥649.[2]

The pestle is the consumable. The bowl is the heirloom.

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS WARN ABOUT GRANITE AND THE SURIBACHI

From Hungry Onion, the forum the Chowhound diaspora built, usernames as posted. **bcc** keeps a heavy granite set from a Thai grocery and cleans it with perfume-free dish soap, reporting no odour retention — the honest correction to the never-soap slogan. **travelmad478**: "Heavier is better". **Chemicalkinetics** runs both and names the trade-off exactly: a hard pestle wears a Motoshige-style suribachi's grooves down, while wooden pestles shed into the food and need replacing. And the warning that should decide a purchase — **meatn3**'s black granite mortar with a white stripe through it "cleanly split in half" along the stripe after a year. **A contrasting vein is a fault line.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE MORTAR PREMIUM IS THEATRE

America's Test Kitchen timed the machine against the hand and found no fragrance difference between mortar-ground and blade-ground pepper and garam masala — fifteen seconds against eight to twenty minutes. It did find mortar-made pesto and curry paste silkier: the mortar wins at wet pastes and ties at dry spices. **On fakes:** cement castings sold as stone are an industry in Indonesia, and the trade press there tests better than the food press — real stone is grey not jet black, rough not smooth, and **a knife scratch leaving a white mark means cement.**[4] **On price:** the object that leaves a Tulungagung carver's yard at under US$4 and sells at a Thai grocer for US$35 retails here as a badged set at **S$292**. Cole & Mason is a label inside a group that also owns AdHoc; Mason Cash and Typhoon are two labels of one company. **None of them cuts stone. And in Singapore:** ToTT's whole mortar category is three AdHoc items, all under 14cm and below the useful floor, one of them cast iron, which acid rusts in this climate; Sia Huat on Temple Street is the right address, but the one mortar this desk could price there is listed "SMOOTH BLK".[5] And the uncomfortable one: KROK sells an Ang Sila mortar at US$125 marketed as lighter and super-smooth — the two properties the testing literature calls defects, recast as features.[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Carbon-steel frying pans — de Buyer, Matfer and Turk's one-piece forgings, at a third of copper, and who actually spins the blanks.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — Nambu ironware from Morioka and Mizusawa, sand-mould casting, and whether the iron really changes the water.

Donabe & clay cooking pots — Iga-yaki from Nagatani-en, La Chamba blackware and the Spanish cazuela: the oldest cooking technology still in daily professional use.

SOURCES 1 America's Test Kitchen's mortars and pestles review, **read at source**, for the grip finding quoted, the five-pound floor, the bowl dimensions, the timings and the fragrance finding. 2 Global Kitchen Japan's and Rikumo's own listings for every price; Motoshige's distributors for the 1925 founding and the quoted division of labour; Nagamochi's guide for the kushinome grooves. **No sanshō-wood pestle could be priced at source anywhere.** 3 Masienda's own instructions and Saeng Douangdara's method. 4 IDN Times, read at source and translated here. 5 Hungry Onion, July 2018, read in full, usernames as posted. **Reddit and Serious Eats both refused this desk, so there is no r/BuyItForLife material and no Kenji López-Alt.** 6 Rayware's own About page; KROK's own store; the two reviews' own disclosures. **The Cole & Mason sourcing and the S$292 are from listings in a search index.** 7 ToTT's and Sia Huat's own stores. **No Geylang Serai stall could be confirmed and none is named.**

TECHNOLOGY · ANTHROPIC'S SHARE OFFERING

Anthropic registers a US$74bn offering, and its own suppliers are buying the shares

Google signed a ten-billion-dollar purchase agreement on 10 November, filed as exhibit 10.15. Against that sit roughly US$900bn of committed payments for computing power.

Anthropic filed a second amendment to its share registration with the American securities regulator on Tuesday 10 November, registering up to US$74,002,500,000 of stock at a maximum price of $78 a share. Trading is expected around 19 November.[1]

The structure is what matters here, and it is simpler than the paperwork makes it look. So the suppliers of a boom are now financing the customer who pays them — and the customer's principal promise to investors is that it will go on paying them for years.[1]

One leg of this is verifiable at source and the rest is not yet. Exhibit 10.16 is a blank form of the same agreement — meaning there are others. Reports put the placement at **US$26bn**, with Nvidia matching Google and AMD, Broadcom, Micron, Microsoft and TSMC also in; **only the Google leg appears in the filings this desk read.**[1]

On the other side of the ledger sit the commitments. An earlier amendment of 2 November carried US$895.4bn.[2]

A smaller detail is worth the ink. And the 10 November filing discloses that the company has met a threshold in its own scaling policy: that its systems now do enough of its research to roughly double the rate at which its models improve.[3]

The suppliers of the boom are financing the customer who pays them.

$3.4bn

PAID FOR 1.7 GIGAWATTS OF GAS-FIRED GENERATORS, RATHER THAN WAIT FOR THE GRID — THE LARGEST KNOWN PURCHASE OF GENERATING PLANT BY AN AI COMPANY.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAYS ABOUT ANTHROPIC AND GOOGLE

Bearish, and specific. On the Hacker News thread about the valuation — 322 points, 634 comments — **cmiles8** notes the figure has walked down from two trillion to one and a half to possibly one, writes that "Anthropic doesn't own compute, they rent it", and puts fair value at two to four hundred billion. **dgellow** calls annualised-revenue reporting "bullshit, non-standard". The bull case, from **bitmasher9**, is that in competitive environments "marginally better is enough to create large advantages". **Every figure posted in that thread is an unverified commenter claim and none is printed as fact here. Matt Kennedy** of Renaissance Capital offers the fairness point: Anthropic "should not be put in a harsher public spotlight than OpenAI just because it's public".[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE REASONS ANTHROPIC'S US$74BN IS OVERSTATED

First, the registered amount is not the deal. US$74.0bn is the ceiling at the top of the range including the over-allotment. Price at $70 with no over-allotment and the offering is about **US$57.75bn** — still a record, and 22 per cent smaller than the headline. **Second, the valuation is falling, not rising. That 40 per cent is this desk's own calculation, on a placement total it could not verify in the filings.**[6]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Washington postponed the affiliates rule again, with a day to spare. Law firms had told clients to prepare for reimposition on 10 November. **The rule gives no reason at all**, and is silent on what happens in January.[7]

TSMC had its largest month ever and the arithmetic is awkward. Its 10 November filing puts October revenue at **NT$586,890m**, up 14.7 per cent on September and 59.7 per cent on a year earlier. It separately played down a report that it would make memory for Nvidia, after its shares fell 10.78 per cent and rose 6.26 per cent in two days on it.[8]

SOURCES 1 Anthropic's Form S-1 Amendment No. 2 of 10 November and its exhibits, **read at source line by line** — the fee exhibit for the $74,002,500,000 and the $78 maximum, exhibit 10.15 for the Google agreement, 10.16 for the blank form. **The US$26bn and every participant but Google are as reported, not in the exhibits read.** 2 Fortune, 10 November, and CNBC, 7 November, citing different amendments. 3 Exhibit 10.6; the scaling disclosure via Yahoo Finance. 4 Fortune on the Financial Times' report of 8 November. 5 Hacker News item 50394906, read in full; Kennedy via CNBC. 6 Bloomberg's headline of 6 November — **its text is paywalled and was not read**. 7 91 FR 70789. 8 TSMC's Form 6-K of 10 November. 9 Nvidia's newsroom, 8 November. **A disclosure: this lead concerns the company that makes the model this edition was assembled with, which is why the sceptical case runs at length.**

THE HOME LAB · THE MEMORY SQUEEZE

Scan lists 64GB of DDR5 at £1,140, above its cheapest RTX 5080

TrendForce's spot board had the older DDR4 trading 32.6 per cent above DDR5 per bit on 11 November. The inversion No. 159 reported has widened, not closed.

The British retailer Scan was selling sixty-four gigabytes of ordinary desktop memory on Wednesday 11 November for £1,139.99 including tax — more than its cheapest current top-tier graphics card, at £1,499.99 for a step up. The cheapest kit of the same capacity on the page was £919.99.[1]

This is the artificial-intelligence build-out arriving in a domestic shopping basket. For anyone who runs large language models at home, it inverts the usual advice: the cheap part of the machine has become the expensive part, and the strategy of buying a modest card and an enormous pile of system memory — long the economical route — is now the costly one.[1]

The spot market shows how odd it has become. **The page does not state its currency**, which by convention is US dollars.[2]

On the same retailer's shelf, 128 gigabytes runs to **£2,569.99**, and a Gigabyte RTX 5090 is in stock at **£6,999.98** while most other 5090 listings read "notify me when available" and one says "call for price". The shortage is visible as absence as much as price.[1]

The month's best news for a home machine is therefore a model, not a part. A community-converted version has been downloaded **86,686** times against 7,112 for the official weights, which tells you how people actually run these things.[3]

The cheap part of the machine has become the expensive part.

4.6×

THE EXTRA CONTEXT A THREE-TO-FOUR-BIT CACHE GIVES OVER HALF-PRECISION ON AN RX 7900 XTX, PER VLLM 0.33.0 — THE MOST USEFUL NUMBER OF THE MONTH FOR ANYONE SHORT OF MEMORY.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HOME LABS MEASURE, AND HOW MUCH DDR5 IT TAKES

Real figures, posted by people running it — and every one of them is really a statement about how much DDR5 or card memory you must own at this month's prices. And **hedora** makes the point that sells it — Ripple is genuinely Apache-2.0, unlike the Chinese models that carry usage restrictions, which is why it has a market in regulated deployments regardless of where it sits on a leaderboard.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · RIPPLE-65B'S LEAD IS 0.42 POINTS, AND IT STILL WANTS 37GB

Four objections, and the first is first-hand — none of which is fixed by the DDR5 you just overpaid for. No measured speed on the consumer machine the model card names exists anywhere this desk could find.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Home Assistant 2026.11 absorbed the community add-on store, which the project calls its biggest release ever, and added live video from Matter 1.5 cameras over WebRTC. **The trap:** entities are now named from device, entity and area context, so existing dashboard cards will read differently — and the separate HACS installer stops working at this version.[6]

llama.cpp shipped ten tagged builds on 11 November alone, the headline being OCP FP8 support on CUDA. **It makes no memory or speed claim for the new cache format, and none should be inferred:** its published benchmark measures a weights format and does not state which cache it used.[4]

Nous Research's Arete-27B, published 6 November, is a Chinese open model retrained to drop state talking points — propaganda responses fall from 22 per cent to 0.9 while coding scores rise slightly. **The caveat the card does not address: the judge is an American model, and the two retrained models were scored at a different temperature from the comparison set.**[3]

SOURCES 1 Scan.co.uk's own listings, **read at source** on 11 November, inclusive of tax; Nvidia's own RTX 5090 page, which carries a template placeholder where the price belongs. **Newegg, Micro Center, B&H, eBay and Corsair all refused this desk, so Scan is the single retailer quoted.** 2 TrendForce's spot page, last updated 11 November; the 32.6 per cent is this desk's division. **The contract table on the same page is dated 30 September and is not mixed with the spot figures; the page states no currency.** 3 The Ripple-65B and Arete-27B model cards and their repositories, read at source. **Weight sizes in gigabytes are this desk's arithmetic: neither card states file sizes.** 4 The vLLM and llama.cpp release pages. 5 Hacker News item 50369925, read in full, usernames as displayed. **Reddit refused every request this build, so r/LocalLLaMA does not appear in this issue.** 6 Home Assistant's own release post of 4 November; **its full breaking-change list sits past the hundred-thousandth character and only the first half was read.**

THE KIT · SIGMA'S FP2

Sigma's fp2 ships at S$2,888 in Singapore, without a mechanical shutter

Richard Butler measured the sensor at 14.2 milliseconds and scored the camera 89 per cent. He also found a high-dynamic-range pipeline that cannot be turned off.

Sigma put the fp2 on sale on Wednesday 11 November at US$2,199 for the body, and at S$2,888 including tax from Alan Photo in Singapore. It is a full-frame camera in a body of 376 grams and 112 by 70 by 42 millimetres, with no handgrip, no viewfinder in the box and no mechanical shutter at all.[1]

Two of those absences matter more than the specification sheet suggests. And without stabilisation in the body, the camera is relying on the lens or on a rig. Sigma has made a deliberate little slab designed to be built onto rather than picked up, and priced it a touch under the camera it replaces.[1]

On the first count the news is good, and it is measured rather than claimed. He rated the camera **89 per cent** and gave it a Silver award.[2]

On the second the news is stranger. Sigma rates the same sensor its rivals call ISO 100 at **ISO 320**, and from there holds about **five stops** of highlight information above middle grey, against 3.3 on the Nikon Z6III. Drop it to ISO 100 and the advantage vanishes. The camera outputs high-dynamic-range files, and the mode has no off switch.[2]

Sigma rates at 320 what everyone else calls 100 — and gains five stops for doing it.

S$3,688

THE SINGAPORE KIT PRICE WITH EITHER THE EVF-21 VIEWFINDER OR THE 50MM F2 — THE VIEWFINDER IS A SEPARATE PURCHASE, AND A LARGE ONE.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT L-MOUNT OWNERS SAY ABOUT THE FP2

The sticking point is the bolt-on finder, not the price. Underneath, a reader called **algrove** admitted he had been "trying to figure out what mount the FP2 has", which the editor answered by noting Sigma is an L-Mount Alliance member. Interest is real; brand awareness outside the alliance is thin.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE FP2'S HDR PIPELINE HAS NO OFF SWITCH

The strongest case against the fp2 is not the missing shutter, it is the processing the camera insists on doing. He does not recommend it for everyday general shooting, for use without accessories, or for video diaries.[2]

STILL ON THE SHELF

A Singapore pre-order warning worth reading twice. Alan Photo's own terms take a **S$100** deposit that is "non-refundable and non-transferable", allocate first-come-first-served, and state that "no delivery options are available for pre-orders" — balance paid and camera collected in store. The same page simultaneously shows "Availability: In Stock".[1]

Nikon ZR firmware 2.0 adds the RED-developed Log3G10 curve recorded in ordinary H.265 rather than raw, cutting file sizes sharply, plus user control of high-sensitivity noise reduction. Nikon will say only that it is "scheduled to be available before the end of the year".[4]

Samsung's Intelligent Eyewear opens for pre-order in the United States today, 12 November, through Warby Parker and Gentle Monster, with deliveries expected mid-December. **No price has been announced by anyone**, which is the only number that matters.[5]

Technics EAH-A1000 headphones reach Japan on 19 November at an expected ¥59,400–¥66,000, against US$449.99 elsewhere; 45 hours with noise cancelling on.[5]

SOURCES 1 Sigma's own fp2 specification page and Alan Photo's Singapore listing including its pre-order terms quoted verbatim — **read at source**; US pricing corroborated at Adorama and in New Atlas, 26 October. **A Japanese price and a second Singapore retailer's figures were seen only in search summaries and are not printed.** 2 DPReview's measurement article of 5 November, its image-quality analysis of 6 November and its full review, for the timings, the sensitivity rating, the score and every quoted passage. 3 Macfilos, comments of 23–29 October, with dates and usernames as published. **Reddit and the DPReview forums both refused this desk.** 4 DPReview, 4 November. 5 SamMobile and Gentle Monster for the 12 November date, which originates in a results filing **this desk could not open**; Technics pricing via TechTimes and Gear Patrol.

THE GOOD LIFE · GENEVA WATCH AUCTION XXIV

Phillips sells an F.P. Journe Résonance for CHF 8,680,500, eight times its estimate

The Geneva sale made CHF 92,045,568 — the first watch auction to pass a hundred million US dollars. Thirteen Journe lots were more than a third of the total.

Phillips sold a platinum F.P. The sale as a whole made CHF 92,045,568, or US$112,277,184 — the first watch auction to clear a hundred million dollars. Every one of the 217 lots sold.[1]

A sale where everything sells is not quite the triumph it sounds, and it is worth saying why before the numbers get away. What it does measure, unambiguously, is where the money went.[1]

It went to one living watchmaker. **Thirteen F.P.** Journe lots made CHF 31,807,850 between them — 34.6 per cent of the sale. Besides the Résonance there was a titanium Tokyo boutique piece at CHF 6,146,000 and a pre-production example at CHF 4,936,000. The house recorded **17 lots above a million francs, 24 world records** and 2,121 registered bidders from 69 countries.[1]

The vintage counterweight was a 1945 stainless-steel Patek Philippe split-seconds chronograph, reference 1436, at **CHF 6,267,000** — a record for any split-seconds chronograph. A Rolex 6062 "Stelline" made CHF 2,334,500, a Philippe Dufour Simplicity in platinum CHF 1,968,500, and a reference 3830 CHF 1,270,000, a record for a non-Oyster Rolex chronograph.[1]

The Résonance itself is worth a sentence for what it is rather than what it fetched. Engraving one took an artisan about two days.[2]

Thirteen watches by one living maker were a third of the whole sale.

CHF 47.8m

CHRISTIE'S GENEVA SALE ON 9 NOVEMBER — ITS HIGHEST EVER FOR A WATCH DEPARTMENT, AND MORE THAN DOUBLE LAST NOVEMBER'S CHF 21.6M. FIVE JOURNE RUTHENIUM PIECES ONCE OWNED BY MICHAEL SCHUMACHER EACH PASSED A MILLION.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE READ INTO THE JOURNE RESULT

Two things, both attributable. Phillips' **Aurel Bacs** marked the milestone personally: "As a twelve-year-old boy discovering vintage watches, I never imagined we would go from a few francs to hundreds." **Collector sentiment is absent from this page by necessity** — Hodinkee, WatchUSeek and Reddit all refused us.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT CHF 92M AND 100% SOLD DO NOT PROVE

None of the trade coverage this desk read offered a sceptical line, so here is one built only from Phillips' own published figures. First, concentration: CHF 31.8m of CHF 92.0m came from one living maker across thirteen lots. A sale is not a market when a third of it is one name. Third, 217 of 217 sold is a statement about reserves. **What would settle it:** Journe prices at a sale that is not a curated single-owner showcase.[1]

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Audio-Technica ATH-AWX7000 went on sale on 6 November at US$3,799, and made its first Japanese listening debut at Tokyo's Autumn Headphone Festival on 7 November. At 48 ohms it is far easier to drive than its 490-ohm open-backed sibling.[4]

A hotel of fourteen rooms opens on Awaji Island on 1 December. Balnibarbi's BE WANDERLUST sits on a hilltop in Minamiawaji, seven rooms facing the sea and seven the mountain, with a twelve-seat restaurant open only to guests; rates from about **¥90,000** per room for two with breakfast.[5]

And the object of the week, from Tokyo on 7 November: Brise Audio's FUGAKU tenth-anniversary headphone cable at **¥4,000,000**, about US$25,239, fifteen units, orders closing 31 December. That is a cable.[4]

SOURCES 1 Phillips' own results page for sale CH080426 and its lot pages, **read at source**, for every hammer figure, the total, the sell-through, the records and the bidder count; conversions are the house's own. 2 Phillips' lot 7 catalogue page, for the Régence dial, the Les Ambassadeurs commission and the engraving time. 3 Haute Time and Oracle Time, both 10 November, for the Journe aggregate, the Bacs quotation, the Christie's totals and the bidder-age figure. **Christie's own site and press room refused this desk, so those figures are read at Oracle Time and not at the house, and its top lot is not identified here.** 4 Audio46, 23 October, and ecoustics, 26 October; **Audio-Technica's own site returned 403 twice.** 5 RusTourismNews, 11 November, citing the operator's own release; **the operator's page was not reached, so the rate is one step removed.**

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Godzilla Minus Zero opens to US$30.6m across 3,254 American screens

Rotten Tomatoes has it at 91 per cent from 192 critics. Little White Lies' David Jenkins calls it "a pale, radiation-blackened shadow of the 2023 film".

Takashi Yamazaki's Godzilla Minus Zero took US$30,612,674 from 3,254 North American cinemas over the weekend of 6 to 8 November, in the distributor GKIDS' widest release. The film had opened in Japan on 3 November and premiered at the New York Film Festival on 26 September. Its worldwide total stood at US$64,097,216 on Tuesday.[1]

That American figure is the thing worth pausing on. The sequel to a film that won an effects Oscar in 2024 has now done it, and done it on two and a half hours of subtitles.[1]

A correction first. No. 159 printed the settled American opening as $30,587,672 after No. 158 had carried an estimate. This desk prints Mojo's current figure and withdraws the word "settled"; the second weekend, 13 to 15 November, has not happened.[1]

The critics are warm and the audience warmer: **91 per cent** from 192 reviews on Rotten Tomatoes, a Metacritic score of **74** from 44, and an audience rating of 96 per cent from more than 2,500 verified viewers. Rotten Tomatoes' own summary credits the film with "keeping its epic action rooted in human interest".[2]

Thirty million dollars, in Japanese, with subtitles, in American cinemas.

$104.4m

THE AMERICAN TOP TEN OVER 6–8 NOVEMBER, AGAINST $50.97M THE WEEKEND BEFORE — THE BOX OFFICE MORE THAN DOUBLED WEEK ON WEEK.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT VIEWERS SAY ABOUT GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

The audience verdict splits exactly where the critical one does: the monster is unarguable, the film around it is not. But **Sydney**, at three and a half, wrote that it is "more thematically/narratively ambitious than Minus One, but also messier" — which is the dissenting critics' complaint in a viewer's words.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · LITTLE WHITE LIES RATES GODZILLA MINUS ZERO A FORTY

David Jenkins of Little White Lies filed the lowest score Metacritic displays for the film, a normalised 40, and he is not hedging. "Unfortunately it's not very good," he writes on 4 November, calling the film "a pale, radiation-blackened shadow of the 2023 film". **John Nugent** in Empire puts the milder version at 60: "not as coherent a vision as Minus One". Jenkins's "rushed" and the four-star crowd's "messier" are the same observation from opposite ends.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Ramayana's American share is climbing, not falling. No. 159 carried it at US$52.4m worldwide with 17 per cent of that domestic. It was the second-biggest film in America on Tuesday. No production budget is published by either, so the $30m figure this desk has been quoting remains a claim and not a source.[5]

The Cat in the Hat opened second on **US$20,002,705** from 4,003 screens — the widest release of the weekend, beaten by half.[1]

Queens of the Stone Age enter the British albums chart at number one with *PERFECTH* for the week of 6 to 12 November; The SNUTS, Nickelback and Editors are also new in the top ten. **The Official Charts publishes positions only, so no sales figure is printed here.**[6]

Olivia Rodrigo returns to number one on the American albums chart dated 14 November with *You Seem Pretty Sad For A Girl So In Love*, which entered at the top in June on 485,000 units. **The figure for this week is behind a paywall and is not printed.**[6]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 6–8 November and its title pages, and The Numbers' daily chart for 10 November, all **read at source. Mojo's weekend view carries an estimated flag; its title page does not, and the two agree.** 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic for the aggregates and the consensus line. 3 Letterboxd's own page; usernames and ratings as displayed. **It publishes no numeric average, so none is given; no CinemaScore is listed; Reddit refused this desk all build.** 4 Little White Lies, 4 November, for every Jenkins quotation; the Empire line via Metacritic. 5 The Numbers and Box Office Mojo, both read on 11 November; **the discrepancy between them is reported rather than resolved.** 6 The Official Charts Company's albums chart. **Billboard redirected every request to a paywall and no attempt was made to work around it.**

THE FAMILY DESK · NAGATA IN PEDIATRICS

A five-wave study in Pediatrics finds social media and low mood predict each other

Nagata and colleagues followed 11,279 American children from age twelve. The effects run between 0.03 and 0.07, every anxiety path crosses zero, and one co-author is an expert witness in social-media litigation.

The journal Pediatrics published a five-wave study of 11,279 American children on 1 November, following them from a mean age of twelve. It asked whether troubled social-media use leads to low mood, or low mood to troubled use. The answer it gives is: both, a little, and not every year.[1]

That is a more useful finding than it sounds, and it is worth understanding why before the numbers. This one compares each child *with himself over time*, so it strips out the stable differences between families. What survives that is a real within-person signal — and what survived here is small.[1]

The figures, in standardised terms: problem use predicting later depressive symptoms came in at **.03, .06, .07 and .02** across the four intervals, with only the middle two clearing significance. Depressive symptoms predicting later problem use ran **−.01, .06, .05 and .04** — again two of four. **All eight anxiety paths crossed zero.** Nothing here is larger than .07.[1]

Two limits belong on the page. Its companion commentary, by Jenny Radesky and Sarah Domoff, is titled "It's a 2-Way Street". **The publisher refused this desk, so that commentary's argument beyond its title was not read.**[2]

Nothing in the paper is larger than seven-hundredths of a standard deviation.

18%

OF AMERICAN CHILDREN AGED NINE TO TWELVE WHO USED AN AI CHATBOT ON THE PREVIOUS DAY, AGAINST 49 PER CENT WHO HAVE EVER USED ONE. REACH IS NOT HABIT.[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW PEDIATRICS ITSELF READ THE SOCIAL-MEDIA FINDING

The journal published a commentary alongside Nagata's paper, by **Jenny Radesky** of Michigan and **Sarah Domoff** of Albany — both front-rank children's-media researchers, Radesky an author of American paediatric media guidance. **This desk could read no further than the title: the publisher returned 403 on both the article and its identifier, so the commentary's argument is not reported here.** For scale underneath the finding, the 2026 Common Sense census puts social-media use among nine-to-twelves at **50 per cent on a given day**, for a median of one hour twenty-five.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · RESEARCHERS WARN AGAINST READING NAGATA AS ALARM

The strongest case against treating Nagata's social-media finding as evidence for a crackdown comes from the field itself. General guidance, not medical advice: nothing here supports reading a child's low mood as caused by a phone.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Parents and children are not arguing about chatbots. They are describing different objects. The one risk both name at almost the same rate is dependence, 19 against 16. Parents see what leaks out; children see what they went there for. **It is a preprint, and its coding was applied at scale by a language model.**[4]

Reach is not habit. In the same census, **49 per cent** of nine-to-twelves have ever used an AI chatbot and **18 per cent** used one on the previous day.[3]

SOURCES 1 Nagata JM and others, "Problematic Social Media Use and Depressive and Anxiety Symptoms in Adolescents", *Pediatrics* 158(5):e2025075060, 1 November 2026, **read in full at source**, for the sample, the design, every coefficient and the declared conflicts. 2 Radesky J and Domoff SE, *Pediatrics* 158(5):e2026077848; authors, date and type verified at Europe PMC. **The publisher returned 403 on both the article and its identifier, so only the title was read.** 3 The 2026 Common Sense Media census, 27 October, **read at source as a PDF**: 1,211 American children aged nine to seventeen, fielded 29 April to 11 May, margin of error 3.2 points. **Its questionnaire was redesigned, so its time-use figures are not comparable with earlier waves.** 4 Berkane T and others, arXiv:2609.20720, 17 September 2026. **Not peer-reviewed.** 5 Maheux AJ and others, *AI & Society*, 25 September 2026, read in full. **Reddit was unreachable all build, so no parenting-forum sentiment is quoted on this desk.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE PSLE FORTNIGHT

Singapore lists PSLE results for 24 November, with secondary choices due seven days later

The Examinations and Assessment Board calls the dates tentative. Posting to secondary schools follows on 18 December, also tentative.

Singapore's Examinations and Assessment Board lists this year's Primary School Leaving Examination results for Tuesday 24 and Wednesday 25 November, and labels the dates tentative on its own page. Its footnote is unusually candid: "the actual dates of the results release can only be confirmed when all processes have been completed".[1]

For a household with a child in the final year of primary school, that fortnight is the whole desk. The results arrive, and a form choosing secondary schools closes about a week later, with posting in mid-December. It is the first decision in a Singapore childhood that the child is old enough to argue about and not old enough to make alone — and the research that bears on it is less about which school than about sleep, phones and the fact that the band in question behaves differently from the one just above it.[1]

That band distinction is the fortnight's most useful finding, and it is new. A study of **48,844** Korean students published in the Journal of School Health on 1 November found that heavy phone use — above four hours a day — tracked worse school performance with an odds ratio of **0.47** in middle school against **0.65** in high school. The association is *stronger* in the younger band, not weaker.[2]

The counterintuitive half is the sleep result. Among the older students, shorter sleep went with *higher* odds of better marks — the exam-culture effect, where the hours come out of the night. Among the middle-schoolers that pattern was absent entirely. The interaction between school level and sleep was significant at **p<0.001**; the one between school level and phone use was not. **General guidance, not medical advice, and the design is cross-sectional and self-reported.**[2]

The phone association is stronger in the younger band, not weaker.

63%

OF TWELVE-YEAR-OLDS IN THE 2026 AMERICAN CENSUS WHO OWN A SMARTPHONE, AGAINST 57 PER CENT AT ELEVEN AND 47 AT TEN — THE OWNERSHIP CLIFF SITS EXACTLY AT THIS YEAR.[3]

65%

OF TWELVE-YEAR-OLDS WHO HAVE EVER USED AN AI CHATBOT, AGAINST 55 PER CENT AT ELEVEN. BOTH CURVES BEND AT THE SAME AGE.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT MEASURED PHONE USE DOES TO SLEEP, JUST PAST THE PSLE

The strongest methodological advance in the window is a study that stopped asking and started measuring. Researchers at Stony Brook recorded **218** adolescents' actual on-device use by passive sensing for an average of 17.5 days, rather than relying on self-report. **The caveat that matters here is the band:** the sample is thirteen to eighteen. It does not contain a twelve-year-old, and should be read as the year ahead rather than the year in hand.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · BOTH PHONE STUDIES MEASURE THE WRONG THING

The sharpest objection to the Korean and Stony Brook results — and to reading either against a Singapore PSLE candidate — is aimed at the exposure variable they share. The Korean study's own authors stress that their exam culture is doing some of the work, and the design cannot show direction. **What would settle it:** a measured-use study inside the eleven-to-thirteen band that distinguishes what the hours contained.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Singapore Examinations and Assessment Board's own "Important Dates for Candidates" page, **read at source**, for the listing, the tentative label and the footnote quoted verbatim. **The Ministry of Education's posting pages returned empty bodies, so the release time, the seven-day window and the 18 December date are given as tentative.** 2 Enkhjin T and others, *Journal of School Health* 96(11):e70271, 1 November 2026, abstract read at source; 48,844 surveyed, 31,902 complete cases. **Subscription-only: the full text was not read.** 3 The 2026 Common Sense Media census, read at source, for the age-by-age figures. 4 Mathew GM and others, *Journal of Adolescent Health*, epub 6 November 2026. **Its abstract pairs intervals in a run-on form, so no single coefficient is set in type.** 5 Maheux AJ and others, *AI & Society*, 25 September 2026. **Reddit refused this desk throughout; there is no forum sentiment on this page.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE DECEMBER MEETING

Fed governor Waller leans toward a December rise; markets price 88.8 per cent

American core inflation printed 0.3 per cent on Tuesday, a third month without improvement. The Bureau of Labor Statistics published no annual rate at all: October 2025 was never collected.

The US Bureau of Labor Statistics published October's consumer price index at half past eight on Tuesday 10 November: prices up 0.4 per cent on the month overall, and up 0.3 per cent once food and energy are stripped out. Two hours earlier, in London, the Federal Reserve governor Christopher Waller had said he was "leaning toward supporting an increase in our policy rate of 25 basis points" in December.[1]

This is a reversal, and it is the thing to carry out of the week. It printed at exactly 0.3. A possibility that did not exist on Monday was priced by Tuesday afternoon.[1]

The oddity underneath is that nobody can say what inflation has done over the past year. The most consequential monetary decision in two years is being taken off a three-month run-rate with the year-ago comparison missing.[2]

Now the mechanism, because one force is pricing four assets differently. That is a market that believes the tightening will work, not one frightened of inflation.[3]

A rising real risk-free rate is a direct charge on anything that pays no coupon. Bitcoin is down about 14% on the year. When the risk-free real rate is 2.78%, "store of value" is not a category that protects you; it is a category that pays you nothing.[4]

And then equities went up anyway. **That decoupling is the fragility**: the same real yield now crushing gold raises the hurdle rate on every multi-year datacentre, and equities have not yet been asked about it.[5]

Nominal yields rose and expected inflation fell. The entire move was real.

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY 11 NOVEMBER'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	CHANGE
VWRA[6]	$189.62	▲ 1.46%
AGGU[6]	$5.81	▼ a shade
US 10-year[3]	4.98%	▲ 10bp
US 2-year[3]	4.73%	▲ 17bp
US 10-year real[3]	2.78%	▲ 12bp
Inflation compensation[3]	2.20%	▼ 2bp
Dollar index[6]	102.95	▲ 0.70%
USD/JPY[6]	159.87	▲ 0.74%
USD/SGD[6]	1.2849	▲ 0.29%
Brent[6]	$92.53	▲ 1.14%
Gold[6]	$3,991.10	▼ 0.97%
Bitcoin[6]	$74,646	▲ 1.26%
Straits Times[6]	5,289.66	▲ 0.59%

There is no 11 November Treasury yield: the American bond market was shut for Veterans Day, so every yield above is Tuesday 10 November's close. Currencies and bitcoin have no close and are snapshots near 21:10 GMT. Not advice.[3]

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

Name the regime: not higher-for-longer but higher-from-here, and the whole move is in real rates. Explanation, not advice.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE AGAINST A DECEMBER RATE RISE

Three credentialed arguments that the consensus is wrong, and they do not agree with each other. Forecasts, flagged as forecasts.[7]

Next prints: American producer prices on Friday 13 November, the November employment report on 4 December, and the rate decision on 8–9 December — with November's inflation figure landing on 10 December, the day after.[2]

SOURCES 1 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own October release, **read at source**; Waller's London remarks of 10 November via CNBC for both quoted passages. 2 The Bureau's own release and 2026 schedule, including its statement that October 2025 was not collected and the three surviving twelve-month lines. 3 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and real yield files for November, **read at source — the latest row is 10 November; there is no 11 November row**; the breakeven is the St Louis Federal Reserve's published series, and reconciles with the subtraction. 4 Levels as below; the fund-outflow figure and the gold peak are as reported. 5 Yahoo Finance's market record for 11 November. 6 Each level read at its own quote page. **The bond proxy moved one cent on a $5.81 price; no percentage is printed.** 7 Strategist comment as published 10–11 November. **The 88.8 and 11.2 per cent are CME's as reported: its own tool returned 503 to this desk all build.** Market explanation and education, not investment advice.

THE INVITATION · CHANGE RINGING

The Central Council counts Britain's change ringers for the first time since 1988

The Central Council's census runs 16 to 22 November. Its own estimate is that the 41,000 ringers of 1988 are now about 30,000, and that 60 per cent of them are over sixty.

Change ringing is the English practice of swinging very heavy church bells through a full circle to sound mathematical permutations, and from Monday the people who do it will be counted for the first time since 1988. The Central Council of Church Bell Ringers opens its Ringing Census on **16 November**, four days after this page is printed.[1]

Begin with the physical oddity, because everything else follows from it. A half-tonne of bronze is being controlled by feel.[2]

Because each bell has enormous inertia and can only move one place at a time in the order, you cannot play a tune on a ring of bells. The patterns are called methods, and the app that carries the Council's own library ships **more than 23,000 of them**.[3]

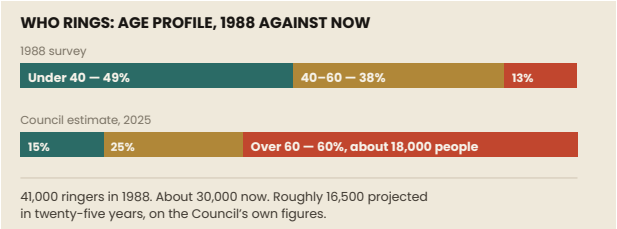
The arithmetic is the sport. Two real examples from this month: 5,056 Cambridge Surprise Major at Harlow on 7 November, **three hours and three minutes**; 5,040 Doubles at Brailsford on 6 November, two hours fifty.[4]

Most ringing is not that. And the typical instrument is smaller than the cathedral image suggests — across all 6,297 currently ringable rings the **median tenor is 1,204 pounds**, about 546 kilograms, and the commonest ring is six bells, in 2,908 towers.[5]

Half a tonne of bronze, controlled by feel, by someone who cannot see it.

6,297

RINGABLE RINGS WORLDWIDE. 6,136 ARE IN THE BRITISH ISLES; **161 ARE NOT** — AUSTRALIA 73, THE UNITED STATES 47, NEW ZEALAND AND CANADA 10 EACH, AND ONE IN SINGAPORE.[5]



From the Central Council's Ringing 2030 business plan, which publishes both rows itself. *Meridian original.*[7]

THE CHATTER · HOW PEOPLE DESCRIBE FALLING INTO CHANGE RINGING

None of the people the Central Council will count next week came to it the same way. **Allie Lyo**, Birmingham: "I had never realised church bells were rung by actual people until I randomly stumbled into a church and was told all about this amazing tradition!" — and, when her Saturday classes finished, "I felt quite empty without school." **Sam Clanford**, six months in at Fornham St Martin in Suffolk, writes the best sentence anyone has produced about it: "The dance-like motion of the ropes, the gentle sounds of wheels and ropes shifting above my head and the soft calls of changes in a lilting Suffolk accent; this is where I choose to spend my Tuesday evenings." And a footnote attached to a peal at Clapton in Gordano on 1 November 2026 reads simply: **"First peal for 6, on the second anniversary of his first ringing lesson."**[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY CHANGE RINGING IS COUNTING ITSELF NOW

The census exists because the Council does not know how many ringers it has, and says so. Next week the hobby finds out how small it actually is.[7]

What follows on these two pages is the descent: who gathers where and what they argue about, what the gear actually costs when the instrument belongs to a church, and the one honest reason this is a harder hobby to join than any amount of money can fix.

SOURCES 1 The Central Council of Church Bell Ringers' own census page, **read at source**, for the dates and the questionnaire window. 2 John Harrison's glossary of ringing terms for the definitions quoted. 3 The Ringing World's own explainer for the worked change; the method count from the Campana listing, which ships the Council's database. 4 Harrison's glossary for peal, extent and peal speed; the two November performances read at source on BellBoard. 5 Computed by this desk from **Dove's Guide's own published dataset**, downloaded 11 November 2026 under its CC BY-SA licence. **Dove's search pages now sit behind an anti-robot interstitial, so the public file was used.** 6 *Tower Talk* 34, February 2026, and a BellBoard footnote, both read at source. 7 The Council's Ringing 2030 business plan, read at source, for every quoted passage and both rows of the age table.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR YOU CANNOT BUY

Bells of Whitechapel sells a new twelve-bell change-ringing set for £5,898 plus VAT

A good used Malmark twelve is £3,250 on the national small-ads board. The tower bells themselves cannot be bought at all: they belong to a church.

Change ringing has a structural oddity no other hobby shares: you cannot buy the instrument. A ring of bells belongs to a church. Everything else is somebody else's building project.[1]

That makes the handbell the one genuine buy-once purchase in the hobby, and it is a real one. The Council's own guide specifies the change-ringer's ideal set as twelve diatonic bells — the white notes of a piano — and notes that a thirteenth lets you make up a heavy six and a light six at once.[1]

The famous name survived its own closure. It is also the British agent for Malmark, whose American list puts a twelve at **US$6,475**.[2]

The second-hand board is where the real prices live, and this is the table that matters. Used runs at a half to a third of new.[3]

What the community warns about is not price but fit. Worse, clappers are set differently for the two disciplines — change ringing needs an equal strike at both strokes — **"This is a reason why some sets of bells are designated for either change ringing or tune ringing."**[1]

A beautiful set of handbells can be the wrong set, and you cannot hear it in the shop.

£20

ABEL, THE WINDOWS SIMULATOR BY CHRIS HUGHES AND SIMON FEATHER, IN CONTINUOUS DEVELOPMENT FOR DECADES — AND ALL PROFITS GO TO CHARITY. ITS PHONE SIBLING IS £5.99.[4]

£49.50

EACH, FOR EBELLS — 3D-PRINTED MOTION-SENSING HANDBELLS WEIGHTED TO 200G TO FEEL LIKE BRONZE, DESIGNED BY "A SMALL GROUP OF RINGER-ENGINEERS". A PAIR PLUS POSTAGE IS £107.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHERE CHANGE RINGERS GATHER, AND WHAT THEY ARGUE ABOUT

The small-ads board where a used Malmark twelve changes hands runs on the same volunteer culture as everything else here. **The Ringing World** has published weekly since 1911 and has about **2,300 subscribers** — roughly one ringer in eleven. Two serious men arguing about whether the hobby can count itself, seven months before it tried.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE ONLINE BELFRIES DID NOT LAST

The pandemic was supposed to digitise change ringing permanently. It did not. Ringing Room let bands ring together in a browser, and performances logged on it ran to **2,738 in 2021**. By 2025 that was **363**, and in 2026 to date **252** — about nine per cent of peak. Handbell Stadium's site still carries a 2020–21 copyright and publishes no version or release date. The reason is not technical. **A simulator lets you learn the lines.** It does not let you ring — and the Council's own handbell guide says the same of the in-hand alternative: "Ringing handbells is typically a group activity." The thing the software cannot supply is five other people in the room.[6]

THE GLOSSARY THAT UNLOCKS THE REST

Sally — the woolly grip on the rope. **Row** — one sounding of every bell. **Change** — the move from one row to the next. **Rounds** — the bells in order, 123456. **Method** — a defined sequence of changes. **Extent** — every possible row once: 720 on six bells, 5,040 on seven. **Bob** and **single** — the calls that steer it. **Conductor** — the ringer who makes them and who is also ringing.[7]

SOURCES 1 The Central Council's own *Handbells — A Brief Guide*, **read at source**, for the twelve-bell specification, the tone and clapper passages quoted verbatim and the group-activity line. 2 Bells of Whitechapel's own site for its prices, licence and Malmark agency; Malmark's own American site. **John Taylor publishes no handbell price and the page the Council cites now 404s; Schulmerich's list was not reached.** 3 The Handbell Ringers of Great Britain small-ads board, read at source on 11 November; asking prices as published. 4 AbelSim's, Beltower's and eBells' own sites and the app stores. 5 BellBoard's own search, queried 11 November; The Ringing World's 2023 report for the subscriber estimate and its 2025 minutes for the quoted concerns; list-archive counts computed by this desk. 6 As 5. **Reddit refused this desk, so r/bellringing's size is stated nowhere on this desk.** 7 Harrison's glossary.

THE DEEP END · THE PRICE IS TUESDAYS

John Harrison showed Ring for the King's recruitment gains halved within two years

His study used 65 years of one guild's membership rolls. Meanwhile Ringing 2030 planned £57,900 of spending in 2025 and spent £6,213.

Change ringing recruits in bursts, and a ringer has now shown in its own weekly magazine that the bursts do not hold. John Harrison's study, published on 19 September 2025, used sixty-five years of membership figures from the Oxford Diocesan Guild — about seven per cent of British ringers — because national numbers are, as he puts it, notoriously hard to find out.[1]

The pattern repeats across three national campaigns. **Ring for the King** in 2023 added 200 members, about nine per cent — and by 2025 half of that had gone too.[1]

His diagnosis is the most useful thing written about why this hobby cannot scale, and none of it is about money. Then recruits who joined to support the cause rather than to ring, short-term targets that end on the day, and bands that stop recruiting once comfortable.[1]

The institutional answer is funded at a rounding error. Its trustees wrote the warning themselves: otherwise "the monies spent will have been wasted".[2]

And the building is not theirs. Nearly half of Britain's rings — **3,472 of 7,262** — have no listed practice night, and **965 are marked unringable**. One complainant starts it; Witheridge's parish council spent over £2,000 altering a clock after a single complaint. A hundred-and-fifty-year-old soundscape can be switched off by one neighbour.[3]

The currency is not money. It is Tuesday evenings, for twenty years, in a cold room, with five other people.

£110

THE ENTIRE HONEST SHOPPING LIST TO BECOME A COMPETENT CHANGE RINGER: NOTHING ON DAY ONE, £20 OF SOFTWARE IN MONTH THREE, AND A MAGAZINE SUBSCRIPTION IF YOU WANT ONE.[4]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE HAS THE ONLY RING IN SOUTHEAST ASIA

St Andrew's Cathedral has twelve bells hung for full-circle ringing, plus a spare, and people are ringing them. It is one of just 161 ringable rings outside the British Isles. There is even handbell ringing logged in a Singapore flat. **One housekeeping note from Dove: the cathedral's own bells page returns a 404 and no replacement has been found, so this is a Sunday visit, not a web form.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT CHANGE RINGING ACTUALLY COSTS TO JOIN

The honest finding about the money is that there barely is any, and that is precisely the problem. There is no upgrade treadmill here, because you do not own the instrument. Everything else is £20 software and an £82 magazine. **What the hobby demands instead is attendance.** That is a far steeper price than money, and it is the one Ringing 2030 cannot buy down.[4]

NEXT DESCENTS

Pigeon racing — the last working-class sport with a stud book: €100,000 birds clocked home from 500 miles, as the clubs that invented it empty out.

Planted freshwater aquascaping — carbon dioxide, Dutch street-plans and Japanese iwagumi stone, in a hobby whose job is to stop a living system winning. Singapore is one of its capitals.

SDR & signal hunting — a £25 dongle that turns a laptop into a receiver for the whole spectrum, and the insomniacs who use it to find numbers stations and weather satellites.

SOURCES 1 John Harrison, "Recruitment drives — how effective are they?", *The Ringing World*, 19 September 2025, **read in full at source**, for the guild series, all three campaigns and every quoted passage. **It is one guild used as a proxy, and he says so.** 2 The Ringing 2030 business plan and the audited 2025 trustees' report, both read at source, for the forecast, the actual and cumulative spend, the staffing, the grant, the reserves projection and the trustees' warning quoted verbatim. **The per-recruit figure is this desk's division.** 3 Dove's Guide's own coverage statistics; the Council's Guidance Note 7 for the statutory position and both parish cases. 4 *Tower Talk* 34 and the Association of Ringing Teachers' published scheme. 5 Dove's Guide tower 11324 and BellBoard's Singapore performances, both **read at source**, for the weights, founders, dates, the named band and the footnote quoted. **Dove records that the cathedral's own bells page was removed in April 2026 after returning a 404.**

FITNESS · THE SURREY SUPPLEMENT TRIAL

A Surrey trial finds a longevity supplement lifts artery function by 2.9 points

European Heart Journal Open published it on 4 November. The placebo group was seven years older than the treatment group, and every blood-lipid result was null.

The European Heart Journal Open published a six-month randomised trial on 4 November in which a fifteen-gram daily supplement improved blood-vessel function by 2.9 percentage points against a placebo. It was run at the University of Surrey by Professor Christian Heiss, funded by the supplement's maker, and enrolled sixty-one people over forty.[1]

The measurement at the centre of it needs a sentence. It is the standard laboratory marker of vascular health. It is also a *surrogate* — a stand-in for the outcomes anyone actually cares about, which are heart attacks and strokes, and which this trial was neither designed nor sized to measure.[1]

The results, as published: dilation improved by **2.9 points** (interval 2.1 to 3.8, p<0.0001); arterial stiffness fell by **1.18 metres per second**; systolic blood pressure fell **6.1 mmHg**. **Four of eleven outcomes reached significance, and the low-density figure moved the wrong way.**[1]

Two things deserve credit before the criticism. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

Four of eleven outcomes cleared. The cholesterol figure moved the wrong way.

61 → 43

RANDOMISED AGAINST ANALYSED: THE PUBLISHED ANALYSIS IS COMPLETE-CASE, SO ABOUT 30 PER CENT OF PARTICIPANTS DROPPED OUT, MOSTLY UNEXPLAINED.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IS MISSING FROM THE SURREY TRIAL COVERAGE

An absence, reported as one. **And the blood pressure was obtained in people who were not hypertensive to begin with — 128 over 75 at baseline — and read on only two days.** This desk found no forum or podcast discussion of the trial it could verify, and attributes none.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · BRAD STANFIELD ON THE SURREY EFFECT SIZE

Dr Brad Stanfield, a physician who was not involved, put the objection plainly on 6 November: "It's an exciting result, but the effect size is surprisingly large." His substantive point is the surrogate: he says he knows of no trial showing that raising flow-mediated dilation with a treatment prevents heart attacks. In a trial about ageing, the untreated arm was seven years older. **The outlet that published Stanfield's criticism discloses its own financial ties to the manufacturer, and printed it anyway.**[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A ring tells you how much to trust the ring. The National University of Singapore's sleep laboratory compared an Oura ring against a sleep-measuring headband across **210 nights** in 45 older adults, published 4 November. The ring underestimated total sleep by 14.6 minutes and **rapid-eye-movement sleep by 23.8 minutes**, and overestimated time to fall asleep by 11.4. **Mean age 74; this is not a validation in the mid-forties.** Unlike the study this desk ran at No. 132, the ring's maker is neither an author nor a funder.[4]

Plant against whey, and a meta-analysis that could not have found a difference. Five trials, published 29 October, give a lean-mass difference of **−0.35kg** with an interval running from −2.46 to +1.76. That interval is about five times the lower bound of the training effect this desk reported at No. 159. The honest headline is not that plant protein equals whey; it is that five studies cannot tell, and would not have been able to.[5]

SOURCES 1 "Acute and 6-month vascular effects of a multi-component nutritional supplement", *European Heart Journal Open* 6(6):oeag157, 4 November 2026, **read at source**, for the design, the randomised and analysed counts, every outcome, the baseline age imbalance and the declared funding — investigator-initiated, funded by the manufacturer, one co-author employed by it. 2 The trial registry record, **read through its data interface**, confirming the registered primary outcome matches the published one. **A claim that the registry records a charitable donation to the lead author was checked against it and is not there.** 3 Lifespan.io, 6 November, for the Stanfield quotations and the within-arm figures; NutraIngredients and News-Medical for the absence noted. **No Attia or Huberman commentary on this trial appears to exist, and none is attributed.** 4 Golkashani HA and others, *Sleep Health*, 4 November 2026, from the National University of Singapore. 5 Callegari IOM and others, *JISSN* 23(1), 29 October 2026. **The paper gives 372 participants in its text and 181 in its forest plot without reconciling them.**

THE DIARY · TWO DEADLINES, ONE PREMIERE

Gardens by the Bay opens The Story of Studio Ghibli on 18 December

Resident tickets are $39 adult and $29 child, on sale now. ART SG's two-for-one offer ends at 11.59pm on 24 November, and sumo tickets open at 10am Japan time on 5 December.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

18 Dec–4 Jul ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli · world premiere**
WEST LAWN, GARDENS BY THE BAY · **RESIDENTS $39 ADULT, $29 CHILD; NON-RESIDENTS $49 AND $43**; A $9 BUNDLE ADD-ON ONLINE ONLY · **THE VENUE PUBLISHES 10AM–7PM AND THE EXHIBITION'S OWN SITE 11AM–7PM** — CHECK ON THE DAY YOU BOOK[1]

22–24 Jan ★ **ART SG 2027 · early bird ends 24 Nov**
MARINA BAY SANDS · TWO ADULT SATURDAY PASSES **$44** AGAINST $88; VERNISSAGE PAIR $94 AGAINST $188 · **UNDER-16S FREE WITH A TICKETED ADULT**[2]

27 Nov–3 Jan **Christmas Wonderland 2026**
SUPERTREE GROVE · 6.30PM–11PM — **DATES ARE NOW CONFIRMED ON THE GARDENS' OWN PAGE, WHICH IS NEW** · **BUT THE PRICE LINE STILL READS ONLY "ADMISSION FEE APPLIES", A SEVENTH ISSUE WITH NO FIGURE**; IN 2025 PRICES LANDED ON 13 NOV[3]

20 Nov–3 Jan **Christmas Train Show · Flower Dome**
GARDENS BY THE BAY · NO SEPARATE TICKET — RESIDENT FLOWER DOME ENTRY **$12 ADULT, $8 CHILD**, SO **$28 FOR A FAMILY OF THREE** · **THE ONLY CHRISTMAS ITEM HERE WITH A PRINTED PRICE**, AND OPEN A WEEK BEFORE WONDERLAND[3]

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · *PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN* 21–22 NOV FROM **$40** IS THE TWELVE-YEAR-OLD'S PICK AND RUNS TWO DAYS ONLY; *RAFTA RAFTA* FROM $57.20 · **SIX FREE PROGRAMMES**, THE CHEAPEST CULTURAL WEEKEND IN THE ISSUE — AND IT OPENS IN EIGHT DAYS[4]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ **Hatsu Basho · tickets open 5 December**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ON SALE SAT 5 DEC, 10AM JAPAN TIME**, CARD ONLY, **¥2,000 SERVICE FEE PER TICKET**, PRINTABLE ONLY AT A 7-ELEVEN IN JAPAN · **CHAIR B AT ¥6,000–7,000 A HEAD IS THE PICK**; BOXES ARE SOLD AS FOURS · **THE CURRENT FUKUOKA BASHO IS SOLD OUT ON EVERY SINGLE DAY**[5]

4–11 Feb ★ **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO · **FREE TO WALK; TSUDOME'S 2027 ADMISSION IS NOT YET PUBLISHED** · **THE HOTEL IS THE BOOKING, NOT THE TICKET** — THE ENGLISH SITE STILL SHOWS 2025; THESE DATES ARE OFF THE JAPANESE PAGE · **NO EDITION NUMBER IS PRINTED BECAUSE THE ORGANISER GIVES NONE**[6]

14 Nov–28 Mar **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO · **¥2,400, OR ¥2,200 IN ADVANCE; FREE FOR EVERYONE 18 AND UNDER** · **OPENS TWO DAYS AFTER THIS ISSUE** · TAKE THE FRIDAY LATE CLOSE TO 8PM[7]

31 Oct–28 Mar **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI · **¥2,800 WEEKDAY; JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · HER FIRST SOLO MUSEUM SHOW IN JAPAN IN 24 YEARS · OPEN TO 10PM — **BUT NOT TUESDAYS, WHEN IT SHUTS AT 5**[8]

28 NOV **Niseko Grand Hirafu · season opens**
KUTCHAN, HOKKAIDO · IT OPENS **ON 28 NOV REGARDLESS OF SNOW** · AIM AT EARLY DECEMBER OR MID-JANUARY[9]

7 MAR **Tokyo Marathon 2027 · volunteer window**
RUNNER ENTRY CLOSED IN SEPTEMBER AND THE BALLOT WAS DRAWN ON 11 SEP · **THE OVERSEAS VOLUNTEER DEADLINE IS 23 NOVEMBER, 5PM JAPAN TIME**, AND NEEDS MEMBERSHIP FIRST — TWELVE DAYS AWAY[10]

PLANNING NOTES · WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO ABOUT IT THIS FORTNIGHT

Two hard deadlines and one alarm. ART SG's two-for-one closes **24 November** and halves everything but the top pass; the Tokyo Marathon's overseas volunteer window closes **23 November**. The alarm is **5 December, 10am Japan time**, when January's sumo goes on sale — and the proof it matters is that the tournament running right now is sold out on all fifteen days. **Best value for a twelve-year-old:** free at ART SG with a registered pass, free at both Tokyo museums, $28 for the family in the Flower Dome. **Hold loosely:** Christmas Wonderland, which now has dates but still no price in its seventh issue of asking. **Not listed, deliberately:** two stadium concerts circulating with prices — the venue's own page for one returned 404 and the official seller refused us for both, and quoted prices ranging from $105 to $2,581 are a resale smell, not a fare. Also held: four family shows whose listings render as empty shells, and River Hongbao, whose site still has no dates at all.[11]

SOURCES Every event was re-verified on its promoter's, venue's or official ticketing page on 11 November 2026; quoted wording is theirs. 1 Gardens by the Bay's own page and the exhibition's own site; **the two publish different hours, and Klook returned 403, so a reported gift is not printed.** 2 artsg.com/tickets for every tier and the deadline quoted. 3 Gardens by the Bay's Christmas Wonderland and Flower Dome pages; **the organiser's own site still heads its page "Highlights of Christmas Wonderland 2025".** 4 Esplanade's own listings. 5 The Japan Sumo Association's ticket service, including **the current tournament's sold-out status.** 6 The Sapporo festival's **Japanese** page; **the English one still shows 2025 and gives no edition number.** 7–8 The two Tokyo museums' own pages. 9 Grand Hirafu's season page; **Hakuba is still unannounced.** 10 The Tokyo Marathon's own site. 11 **Omitted for want of a primary read:** two stadium concerts and four family productions whose pages rendered as shells.

THE TABLE · FIVE NEW SINGAPORE OPENINGS

Eatbook scores a seven-country hawker stall in Taman Jurong at 8.5

Nomad Kitchen's founder spent thirty years in hotels before opening a $6 stall. Four of this fortnight's other openings are too new for anyone to have judged.

The only new Singapore opening this fortnight with an actual score against its name is a hawker stall in Taman Jurong that cooks food from seven countries. Nomad Kitchen, at Taman Jurong Market and Food Centre, was rated 8.5 out of 10 by Eatbook in a review dated 27 October, which called the cooking "well-cooked and flavourful".[1]

Its founder, **Fuad Salim**, describes himself as a food-and-beverage nomad and has about thirty years in hospitality behind him, including spells as a food-and-beverage manager and a hotel manager. A career hotelier going backwards into a stall with a $6 dish is the point here; the menu — Iranian, Turkish, Italian, Greek, Moroccan, Saudi and Afghan, made from scratch daily — is the evidence.[1]

The reviewer printed the faults, which is why the score is worth something: the rotisserie chicken is slightly bland, and the location is inaccessible. Afghan Chicken starts at **$6**, Saffron Jujeh is $8, Iskender $12, Shakshuka $7, Moussaka $8. It opens **Tuesday to Sunday, 10am to 3pm only**. The constraint is the clock, not the queue. **The review says the stall is Muslim-owned; it does not say halal-certified, and this desk will not upgrade that.**[1]

At the other end of the island, **Mala Mia** opened in the basement of Changi Airport Terminal 3 in early November, building bowls by weight at **$2.90 per 100g with a 400g minimum** — about $11.60 before you add a base. It is halal-certified. **One piece of coverage exists, published on 11 November.** It is one day old in print and unjudged in practice.[2]

Yeah Gelato, a Beijing-born brand, opened its seventh Singapore outlet and first proper café at Jurong Point, launching three flavours islandwide on 4 November. Three new flavours, two of them gimmicks and one that works. **Explicitly not halal-certified.**[3]

And two that have not opened. The coverage, dated 3 November, says it "is opening" and gives hours as to be decided. The pedigree is proven; the address is not.[4]

One day old in print, and unjudged in practice.

8.5/10 · NOMAD KITCHEN | HALAL · MALA MIA | TOO NEW TO CALL · FOUR OF FIVE | WEST · JURONG POINT

THE BUZZ · WHAT CAN AND CANNOT BE SAID ABOUT THESE FIVE

One verdict, one first look, one tasting note, and two venues that are not open. Mala Mia has a single write-up a day old. **Yeah Gelato** has a tasting but no score. What is left is what local food media actually printed, attributed and dated.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · SOI STORIES IS THE BEST STORY HERE AND THE LEAST VERIFIED

A Thai food street at The Centrepoint with eleven Bangkok concepts, nine curated by the Michelin-starred Bangkok chef known as Chef Ton, is the most exciting item this desk found this fortnight — and it should be read with both hands. It cites a Time Out Singapore announcement as its source, and **timeout.sg returned HTTP 405 to every request.** The Centrepoint's own site rendered as a title-only shell and both its tenant pages returned 404. It is printed here as a flagged lead, not as an opening.[6]

Still on the shelf: Chipotle has confirmed a first Singapore outlet at Jewel Changi for 2027, and Hama-Sushi's Pasir Ris branch still has no Singapore pricing announced.[7]

SOURCES 1 Eatbook, 27 October 2026, **read at source**, for the rating, the quoted verdict, the named faults, the founder's background, the prices and the hours. **No opening date is stated; the review calls it new, so October is inferred and said to be.** 2 Eatbook, 11 November 2026. **One day old, and the only coverage that exists.** 3 Eatbook, 3 November 2026, for the flavours, the quoted tasting notes and the halal statement. 4 Eatbook, 3 November 2026. **Prices from the group's original outlet are deliberately not printed as Wisma Atria prices, because none have been published.** 5 As above. **Reddit, in every form, and Burpple both refused this desk, so no forum or social sentiment appears on this page.** 6 sg.everydayonsales.com, the only readable page, which cites a Time Out Singapore piece that **returned HTTP 405 and was not read**; The Centrepoint's own pages rendered empty or 404. 7 Eatbook. **A sixth candidate was dropped: a rooftop bar whose address is a venue already in this title's Table ledger.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · MONGOLIA'S KIOSKS

Ulaanbaatar sold 1,600 street kiosks, then cleared the streets for CU

Governor's Order A230 of 14 February 2025 began the clearance. Premium Nexus opened its 603rd Korean-branded store in June, and its loyalty app now holds 1.3 million registrations in a country of 3.5 million.

Ulaanbaatar's city government sold its street traders their kiosks — brown steel boxes in 2015, white ones in 2019 — stopped collecting land fees from them in 2020, and in February 2025 ordered the lot cleared away. By the city's own count about 1,600 went. It offered the traders 1,669 jobs and stalls in 48 markets. Twenty-two took a stall.[1]

A joke holds that the capital has become a Korean suburb — "Mongtan", Mongolia crossed with Dongtan, the new town south of Seoul. The joke is wrong, and the way it is wrong is what this essay is about. What has arrived in Ulaanbaatar in eight years is not Korean taste. It is a formal consumer economy, in a country that never built one — and because the state could not build it, the state licensed it instead.[2]

The licensee is **Premium Nexus**, a Mongolian construction and retail group listed on the Mongolian Stock Exchange. In April 2018 it signed a master franchise with South Korea's BGF Retail for the CU brand and ended that year with **21 stores**. At the end of June 2026 it had **603**, in 16 of Mongolia's 21 provinces — 491 of them in the capital, deliberately spaced 150 to 200 metres apart. Its rival GS25, run by the Shunkhlai conglomerate, had about 299.[3]

What the franchise actually bought was not a shopfront but a logistics system. Premium Nexus built a 4,200-square-metre ambient warehouse, a chilled store moving more than 55,000 items a day, and a food factory at Khonkhor that now turns out **more than 60,000 meals daily**. Stores take three or four deliveries a day; **85 per cent arrive between ten at night and seven in the morning**. The company states plainly why this is the product: logistics run at about 30 per cent of total product cost in Mongolia, two to three times the global average.[3]

Read the list of what a CU supplies and the argument assembles itself. The prospectus offers customers "free access to toilets, a shelter in an emergency and a resting point in summer's heat and winter's chill", and calls the company "a support and social infrastructure for the daily life of the community". Add a parcel locker, a bill payment, a tax receipt. The cold chain is a corporate asset. Food safety is a franchise condition. The public lavatory is a loss leader.[4]

> ***The cold chain is a corporate asset. The public lavatory is a loss leader.***

Even age verification is a marketing campaign: CU runs one with the General Police Authority, and a civility campaign jointly with the police *and with* GS25, its competitor. When municipal rubbish collection failed to keep schedule in Bayangol district in 2025, the company signed its own agreement with the district governor and moved 608 tonnes of waste in 618 trips from 71 stores.[3]

The demand side is younger than any market in North Asia. Half of Mongolia's 3.5 million people live in the capital, whose median age is about 25.6; more than half the country is under 30. A Korean format designed for a shrinking, ageing, single-person society fits Mongolia for exactly the opposite reason. And the taste did not arrive by television: **more than 54,000 Mongolians live in South Korea**, the largest Mongolian population anywhere abroad, and they come home having lived inside the format. Mongolians call Korea the twenty-second *aimag* — the twenty-second province of a country with twenty-one.[5]

SOURCES 1 ikon.mn, 15–16 August 2025, **read at source in Mongolian**, for the city's account of roughly 1,600 kiosks moved, 1,669 jobs offered and 22 take-ups; ikon.mn, 25 April 2025, for the 2015 and 2019 purchases from the city, the 2020 waiver and Order A230. 2 The "Mongtan" coinage is Korean, used on the record by President Lee Jae Myung in July 2026 — **a point this essay returns to on p23.** 3 Premium Nexus JSC's own first-half 2026 and 2025 annual reports, lodged with the Mongolian Stock Exchange and **read at source**, for the store counts, the spacing, the distribution and kitchen capacities, the delivery pattern, the logistics statement and the waste agreement; the rival count from the Korea JoongAng Daily, 21 July 2026. 4 The IPO investor handout, read at source, for the quoted passages. 5 National Statistics Office figures as cited by the company and KOTRA; **the Korean-resident figure spans about 54,000 to 61,000 and is given as a floor.**

Against that stands the **ТҮЦ** — *tüts*, short for *türgen üilchilgeenii tség*, "quick-service point". It answered it the only way an uncapitalised economy can — informally, on borrowed money.[1]

How much borrowed money is the fact nobody outside Mongolia has reported. A survey of more than 250 operators by their own association put their combined debts — to banks, non-bank lenders, pawnshops, daily-loan providers and suppliers — at **more than 30 billion tögrög**. The ТҮЦ was never a shop. It was a leveraged livelihood.[1]

The clearance began in April 2025 and **1,278 kiosks were relocated across six central districts by 29 April**. A second round in August took 112 more at 51 locations. Vendors said one removal was attended by more than a hundred police officers. Board member **N.** The associations demanded the annulment of Order A230 and signalled a complaint to the National Human Rights Commission.[1]

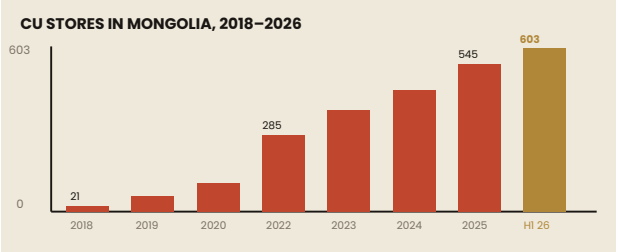
The city's case, from general manager **G.** Batzorig in August 2025, was four charges: the kiosks drew electricity from the state, sold uncertified goods and tobacco, polluted air and soil, and obstructed pedestrians. Mayor **Kh.** Nyambaatar added that concrete had been poured on public land without permits and kiosks placed on top of it, and said owners who failed to remove them would be billed — along with the official who approved the placement.[2]

Now notice what those four charges have in common. The city's compliance agenda and the chain's commercial interest are not merely compatible. They are the same agenda, written once.[2]

The state did not choose Korean gimbap over Mongolian kiosks. It chose the retail form it can count.

That is the mechanism, and it is worth stating without melodrama: the state is not choosing Korean retail over Mongolian retail. It is choosing **legibility** — and only one of the two forms can be read. Premium Nexus ranks **65th in Mongolia by taxes paid** and **second in the entire country by number of insured employees**, with 5,046 staff of whom 91.2 per cent are under thirty. From a treasury's point of view that is precisely what formalisation looks like: not more revenue first, but more *visible* people first.[3]

The clearest statement of the logic came from outside the country. In 2026 the **Asian Development Bank signed a US$10m social loan** with Premium Nexus for retail infrastructure, cold-chain logistics and nationwide expansion, which the company frames as an investment in "Mongolia's food security, supply chain resilience, and inclusive economic growth". A convenience-store chain has been classified as food-security infrastructure, and a development bank has paid for it.[3]



Store network, from the company's own filings. 2021 is omitted: the figure published at the June listing was a mid-year count of 127, not a year-end one. *Meridian original.*[3]

The precedent is in Premium Nexus's own prospectus, which is unusually candid about the wave it is riding. The modern convenience store reached Japan in the 1970s, Taiwan in the 1980s, South Korea in the 1990s and Indonesia in the 2010s, and the document tells investors Mongolia will repeat the pattern — many brands entering quickly and competing hard for a foothold. It also told them in 2021 that it intended to hold 48 per cent of a 754-store Ulaanbaatar market. It has essentially done it.[4]

30bn₮

THE KIOSK OPERATORS' OWN SURVEY OF MORE THAN 250 OF THEIR MEMBERS PUT THEIR COMBINED DEBTS — BANKS, PAWNSHOPS, DAILY LENDERS AND SUPPLIERS — ABOVE THIRTY BILLION TÖGRÖG.[1]

SOURCES 1 ikon.mn, 18 February and 25 April 2025, **read at source in Mongolian**, for the press conferences, N. Uranchimeg's account, the debt survey and the relocation count. **The debt figure is the operators' own survey of their own members and is not audited.** 2 ikon.mn, 15–16 August 2025, for Batzorig's four charges; Mayor Nyambaatar's remarks from his own site, translated. **Neither article carries a response from the chain, and none is implied.** 3 Premium Nexus's own 2025 and first-half 2026 reports for the rankings, the staff profile and the development loan with its quoted framing. **The loan is reported from the borrower's filing only; the bank's own documentation was not read.** 4 The IPO handout for the regional chronology and the 2021 market-share intention. **A tempting parallel with Korea's own corner-shop displacement is omitted: this desk did not verify it.**

Four things cut against this essay, and the first is that "Mongtan" is substantially a Korean artefact. The word was coined by Korean travellers and spread by Korean outlets and a Korean president. One Korean paper's reporter arrived at it by walking two kilometres between a hotel and a press centre during a state visit, counting shopfronts. Another's piece on the phenomenon carries exactly one consumer quote — from a 32-year-old *Korean* office worker. Across three Korean dailies this desk read, almost no Mongolian adult is quoted and not one Mongolian official or analyst appears at all.[1]

The absence of Mongolian voices in that coverage is not a small thing. Across three Korean dailies this desk read, the phenomenon is described almost entirely from the franchisor's side — by the chain, by its competitor, by a Korean agriculture minister on a state visit, and by one Korean office worker who thought the restrooms were fine. A story told by the people selling it should be handled as such.[1]

Second, the scale is smaller than the saturation image suggests. On the company's own citation of national statistics, convenience stores are an obtainable market of **US$800m inside a US$10.7bn** Mongolian retail economy — under eight per cent — and at the 2021 listing the figure was about one per cent. Mongolia still has **4,488 people per convenience store** against South Korea's 1,101. "Wrapped in Korean brands" describes a few central streets, not a national retail system.[2]

Third, the displacement claim is asserted rather than measured, and an honest essay says so out loud. **This desk could not find a single figure for small-shop or kiosk closures attributable to convenience stores, nor any independent Mongolian study of it.** The city's stated reasons were pavement obstruction, electricity theft and uncertified goods — not competition policy. The officials said they paid their own way. **Nothing has been proven, and neither article carries a response from the chain.**[3]

A country can swap a kiosk economy for a convenience-store economy. It cannot franchise demand.

What can be said about the kiosks, then, is narrower than the operators would like and wider than the city would. The city sold them the boxes, waived their fees, and cleared them. The four faults it cited are the four a certified chain is audited against. The associations allege a trip to Korea at the chain's expense; the officials say they paid their own way. None of that is a finding about competition; all of it is a sequence, and a sequence is reportable.[3]

Fourth, and most awkward for the triumphal version, the expansion is missing its own targets and is being bought with debt. GS25 announced 500 Mongolian stores by 2025 and has roughly 299. Premium Nexus's borrowings went from **43.8bn tögrög in June 2024 to 139.5bn in June 2026**, financing costs rose from 9.7bn to 16.6bn, and net margin fell from 4.0 per cent to **1.6**. It still carries an accumulated deficit of 36.8bn. Its own filing lists, under competitive risk, the danger of opening stores too close together.[4]

Which brings the argument to the number that ought to end it, and it is in the company's own half-year report. Two years ago comparable-store daily sales were growing 25.2 per cent and the basket 14.2 against 6.8 per cent inflation — a real increase the company itself put at seven per cent. In the first half of 2026, at the 487 stores open through both periods, daily sales rose **1.7 per cent**, customers 3.3, and **basket value fell 1.6**. Across all 603 stores, daily sales fell 2.0 per cent and customers 3.0.[4]

The chain is now growing by adding doors rather than by selling more through each one. The state swapped a retail form it could not read for one it can tax, inspect, insure and count. It got what it wanted. What it did not get, and could not have licensed from anybody, is a customer with more to spend.[4]

The last detail belongs to the operators, and it is the one that should survive this piece. Ulaanbaatar sold them brown kiosks in 2015 and white ones in 2019, waived the fees in 2020, and demolished them in 2025. They say the city is now bringing in a third generation, in glass. They offered to clean them and to pay tax, and were refused. Whatever else that is, it is not a market outcome.[3]

SOURCES 1 The Korea Herald, 16 July 2026, the Korea Times' notebook of 11 July and the Korea JoongAng Daily of 1 September, all **read at source**; the count of whom they quote is this desk's own. 2 Premium Nexus's market materials citing the National Statistics Office; **its own page gives 4,488 people per store in the table and 4,594 in the text.** 3 ikon.mn, 18 February and 25 April 2025. **Allegations by an interested party; this desk verified only that they were made, and by whom.** 4 Premium Nexus's first-half 2026 report for the comparable-store and system-wide figures, the balance sheet and the competitive-risk disclosure. **Aggregates are this desk's arithmetic on rows the company marks unaudited. On the under-the-radar test: searches of the major Western outlets returned nothing, and no English-language coverage of the kiosk clearance exists at all. The honest claim is that none was found, not that none exists.**

THE LAST WORD

Who is paying whom

The spine of this issue was meant to be a financing structure, and it is: the firms that sell Anthropic its chips and its cloud are buying something like two-fifths of the offering that will pay them (p7). But read the book back and the shape turns up where no money changes hands at all.

Ulaanbaatar sold its street traders their kiosks, waived their fees, and then cleared 1,600 of them away — and the four faults it named were precisely the four a franchised chain is certified against (p21). A development bank has now classified that chain as food-security infrastructure. In Haiti, eighteen hundred soldiers are doing the work of a mandate that covers two hundred of them, under an agreement neither government will publish (p3). Singapore turns out to be where a fifth of Nvidia's revenue is invoiced and almost none of it is installed (p5).

What these have in common is not corruption. It is that the party keeping score and the party being scored have quietly become the same party — and the arrangement works beautifully until somebody counts independently. Which is what makes the smallest story in the issue the one worth keeping. On Monday, English change ringers begin counting themselves for the first time since 1988, knowing already that their own strategy document puts sixty per cent of them past sixty (p15). A thirty-four-thousand-pound programme to recruit ten thousand people is about to meet an actual number.

They did not have to do it. Nobody made them. That is the difference between a count and a receipt — and it is why the figure that will come out of a few thousand English church towers next week is more honest than most of the ones printed in this issue.

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A note on method. Read at source this edition: Anthropic's Form S-1 Amendment No. 2 of 10 November and its exhibits, line by line; TSMC's Form 6-K; the export rule at 91 FR 70789; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October release and the Treasury's own yield files; Amnesty International's Haiti statement; Premium Nexus's filings to the Mongolian Stock Exchange; Dove's Guide's dataset and the Central Council's audited accounts; John Harrison's recruitment study in full; Phillips' own lot pages; Sigma's and Scan's listings; TrendForce's spot board; six journal records; eleven venues' own pages; and ikon.mn in Mongolian for a kiosk clearance never reported in English. **Refused, and said so on the page each time:** Reddit in every form, all build — which is why no forum sentiment appears outside Hacker News, Hungry Onion, Macfilos and Letterboxd; Reuters, the Associated Press and the Miami Herald; Christie's and Hodinkee; Serious Eats; the American Academy of Pediatrics' publisher; Billboard and Bloomberg, both paywalled and neither circumvented; and CME's own rate tool. **Held rather than printed:** the casualty figure at Croix-des-Bouquets, the Paraguayan pension exposure, Anthropic's placement total, Samsung's eyewear price and Christmas Wonderland's admission. **Corrected:** *Godzilla Minus Zero*'s American opening, which No. 159 called settled at $30,587,672 and Box Office Mojo now gives as $30,612,674 (p11); and No. 159's two Iranian units, where the Paris prosecutor names one unit and its parent centre (p4).